

Customer & MVP Blueprint

PlacementOS — AI-Powered Placement Prep Platform for Indian Engineering Students

Market: India (NCR/UP Tier-2/3 Engineering Colleges → Pan-India)	Stage: Pre-Build / Idea Validation	Prepared by: Claude, Startup PM & Customer Research
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Executive Summary

PlacementOS targets a sharply felt, recurring pain point: engineering students at Tier-2/3 Indian colleges lack a single, personalized system to prepare for campus placements. Today's prep is fragmented across YouTube playlists, paid coaching with generic curricula, and informal senior advice that doesn't map to a student's actual skill gaps or target companies. The opportunity is large (millions of students per placement cycle) and the willingness-to-pay precedent already exists (students currently pay for DSA courses, resume reviews, and mock interview packages separately). However, **no validation has been conducted yet** — this report should be treated as a structured hypothesis set to test in the next 30 days, not confirmed market truth.

Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

Attribute	Profile
Institution Type	Tier-2/3 private engineering colleges (AKTU, and similar state-affiliated universities), non-IIT/NIT
Academic Year	2nd–4th year, B.Tech CS/IT/ECE/allied branches
Current Skill State	Basic-to-intermediate DSA, weak aptitude/verbal prep, no structured resume strategy
Placement Status	Pre-placement-season or mid-prep, hasn't cracked a target-tier offer yet
Budget Behavior	Price-sensitive; already spends ₹500–₹5,000/year across scattered courses/resources
Device/Access	Primarily mobile-first, intermittent laptop access via college labs or shared family device
Geography	NCR/UP belt initially; pattern replicable pan-India in Tier-2/3 markets

Buyer Persona

"Confused Coder" Profile	Frustrations & Motivations
Name (archetype): Rohan, 20, 3rd-year B.Tech CS student Goals: Land any product-based or mid-size company offer; stop feeling behind his "CP/DSA topper" peers Daily reality: Juggles coursework, college projects, and scattered self-prep with no clear roadmap Tech comfort: Comfortable with apps/platforms (LeetCode, YouTube, Telegram groups) but overwhelmed by choice	- Doesn't know if he's "on track" compared to placement timelines - Anxious about being rejected at resume-screening stage before even getting an interview - Motivated by visible progress — wants to see skill gaps closing, not just "watch more videos" - Trusts peer proof (seniors who got placed) more than ads or brand claims

Top 10 Customer Pain Points

#	Pain Point	Why It Hurts
1	No personalized roadmap	Generic playlists don't map to the student's actual gaps or target company tier
2	Resume gets rejected pre-interview	Doesn't know what recruiters actually screen for at their target companies
3	DSA practice feels directionless	Solves random problems without a structured difficulty/topic progression
4	No mock interview access	Mock interviews are expensive or require an existing professional network
5	Unclear timeline pressure	Doesn't know if they're "behind schedule" for the placement season
6	Aptitude test prep is an afterthought	Focuses only on DSA and gets blindsided by aptitude-round cutoffs
7	Information overload	Too many free resources, no way to know which ones are worth the time
8	No peer benchmarking	Can't tell if their prep pace is competitive vs. similar students
9	Low confidence in interviews	Never practiced explaining projects/DSA solutions out loud under pressure
10	Limited paid-course budget	Can't afford ₹15k+ bootcamps; needs an affordable, modular alternative

Customer Journey

Stage	Behavior	Key Question in Their Head
Awareness	Sees peer/senior post a placement-prep tip on LinkedIn/Instagram, or searches "how to prepare for placements" on YouTube	"Is there a better way than what I'm doing now?"
Consideration	Compares against free YouTube playlists, LeetCode, and paid bootcamps; checks if peers have used it	"Will this actually get me a job, or is it just another course?"
Purchase	Tries a free tier/sample roadmap; converts on a low-	"Is this worth the money right now, before placements start?"

	friction price point tied to a visible outcome (e.g., "resume score" or "mock interview unlock")	
Retention	Returns if the roadmap updates as skills improve and shows visible progress markers	"Is this actually moving me closer to an offer?"

Key Customer Objections

- **"I can find this for free on YouTube."** — Must counter with personalization and time-saved, not content volume
- **"I don't trust an AI to know what recruiters want."** — Needs visible proof points (placed-student outcomes, recruiter-sourced criteria)
- **"I don't have money to spend before I have a job."** — Price anchoring must feel low-risk (freemium or one-time low fee, not subscription-first)
- **"My college has a placement cell already."** — Must position as a personalization layer on top of, not a replacement for, the college's existing process

Key Buying Triggers

- Placement season officially announced by college (urgency spike)
- A friend/senior gets rejected or selected — triggers comparison anxiety
- First resume rejection — triggers a search for "what am I doing wrong"
- Seeing a peer's visible progress (e.g., LinkedIn "100 days of DSA" posts)

MVP Recommendation

Question	Answer
Build First	A resume gap-analyzer + personalized roadmap generator (input: target role/company tier + current resume → output: skill-gap report and a sequenced 8-week prep plan). This is the highest-perceived-value, lowest-build-cost entry point.
Do NOT Build	Full mock-interview AI simulation, proctored test engine, or a native mobile app — all are expensive to build well and aren't needed to validate core demand. Avoid building a content library from scratch; curate/link existing free resources instead.
Success Metrics	(1) % of users who complete onboarding → see their gap report; (2) % who return within 7 days to check roadmap progress; (3) Free-to-paid conversion rate on the first upsell step; (4) Qualitative: do users describe it as "personalized" unprompted in feedback?

MoSCoW Prioritization

Must Have • Resume upload + gap analysis • Personalized 8-week roadmap • Target company/role selector • Progress tracking dashboard	Should Have • Curated DSA topic sequencing • Aptitude test practice module • Peer progress benchmarking	Could Have • AI mock interview (text-based) • LinkedIn-ready progress badges • College-specific leaderboards	Won't Have (v1) • Native mobile app • Live human coaching • Proctored testing engine
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Pricing Hypothesis

Model	Hypothesis
Freemium	Free gap-analysis report (lead magnet) → paid unlock for full 8-week roadmap + tracking
Price Point	₹299-₹499 one-time per placement cycle (avoid subscription friction for a budget-constrained, one-season-use audience)
Upsell	Optional add-on for mock-interview module or premium DSA tracks at ₹199-₹299
Validation Needed	Test willingness-to-pay via a "fake door" pricing page before building the paid tier

Top 5 Risks

#	Risk	Mitigation
1	Free alternatives are "good enough"	Win on personalization + time saved, not on having more content
2	Low willingness to pay pre-placement	Validate price sensitivity with a fake-door test before building payment infra
3	Trust gap in AI-generated career advice	Show outcome proof (placed students, recruiter-sourced criteria) early and visibly
4	Seasonal demand (placement cycles only)	Plan content/marketing pushes around placement-season calendars; consider off-season retention hooks
5	Founder has no existing validation signal	Run 15–20 customer interviews in week 1 before writing any code

30-Day MVP Plan

Week	Focus
Week 1	Conduct 15–20 interviews with target students; validate pain point severity and willingness to pay; build a landing page with a fake-door pricing test
Week 2	Design the resume gap-analysis logic (rule-based + LLM-assisted scoring); build a clickable prototype for the roadmap output
Week 3	Build the functional MVP: resume upload → gap report → roadmap generator → basic progress dashboard
Week 4	Onboard 20–30 beta users from 1–2 colleges; collect usage data and qualitative feedback; iterate on roadmap accuracy

Founder Action Sheet

- Draft a 10-question customer interview script focused on placement prep pain points
- Recruit 15–20 students (own college network) for interviews this week
- Build a 1-page landing site explaining the value prop with a fake-door "Join Waitlist / Pay ₹299" button
- Post the landing page in 3–5 relevant college WhatsApp/Telegram groups to gauge organic interest
- Define the exact rubric for "resume gap analysis" — what signals matter for Tier-2/3 student resumes
- Build the roadmap-generation logic as a simple rules engine before involving any AI/LLM complexity
- Identify 2–3 placed seniors willing to give testimonials or validate the roadmap logic
- Set up basic analytics (sign-ups, completion rate, return visits) before public launch
- Run the first 20-user beta cohort and document qualitative feedback verbatim
- Revisit pricing hypothesis using real fake-door conversion data, not assumptions

Scores (0-100)

Dimension	Score	Bar
Customer Clarity	70	
Problem Severity	75	
PMF Potential	55	
MVP Readiness	45	

Note: These scores are directional estimates based on category reasoning, not real customer data — since no validation (interviews, surveys, waitlist) has been conducted yet. MVP Readiness is intentionally scored lower because the idea is still pre-build.

Final Verdict

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Promising but Unvalidated

The problem is real and well-understood, and the target customer is sharply definable. But because **zero direct customer validation exists yet** (no interviews, surveys, or waitlist signal), this idea sits at "promising hypothesis" rather than "proven demand." The highest-leverage next step is not building — it's running the Week 1 interview plan above before writing a single line of product code.